

UNIT 1

Introduction and Basic Patient Communication

English for Radiology and Radiotherapy

Learning objectives

- Introduce yourself to a patient in a professional way.
- Give simple and clear instructions during a scan or treatment.
- Ask basic safety questions before a procedure.
- Use essential vocabulary related to patient care.
- Communicate calmly, clearly and empathetically.

Why does communication matter?

- The first interaction can build trust, confidence and a sense of safety.
- Patients cooperate better when they understand what is going to happen.
- Clear communication can reduce anxiety and prevent misunderstandings.
- Professional communication includes both words and non-verbal behaviour.

1. Introducing yourself and greeting the patient

- Start with a simple, friendly greeting.
- Speak slowly, clearly and in a calm tone.
- Tell the patient your name and professional role.
- Explain what you are going to do today.

Useful phrases: introductions

- Good morning, my name is...
- I am your radiotherapy technician.
- I will be performing your X-ray today.
- I will be performing your CT scan today.
- I will be performing your radiotherapy session today.

Class practice: introduce yourself

Work in pairs: one student is the technician and the other is the patient.

Include: greeting + your name + your role + today's procedure.

Change roles after one minute.

Challenge: make the patient feel comfortable using only simple English.



2. Giving basic instructions

- Use short sentences and familiar words.
- Give one instruction at a time.
- Use gestures or demonstrations when necessary.
- Repeat an instruction if the patient does not understand.

Useful phrases: instructions

- Please follow my instructions carefully.
- Lie still during the scan.
- Hold your breath for a few seconds.
- Please do not move.
- You can breathe normally now.

Why are clear instructions important?

- They help the procedure to be performed safely and effectively.
- They reduce movement and improve image quality.
- They can prevent errors during imaging or treatment.
- Clear instructions make the patient feel more confident.

3. Collecting information

- Before starting, check for conditions that may affect the procedure.
- Ask direct, simple questions.
- Safety questions help identify possible risks.
- Make sure the patient understands the question before continuing.

Essential safety questions

- Do you have any allergies?
- Do you have any metal implants?
- Are you pregnant?
- If necessary, repeat or rephrase the question calmly.

4. Key vocabulary

- Appointment — a scheduled time to see a healthcare professional
- Procedure — a medical examination or treatment
- Consent form — a document giving permission for a procedure
- Patient — a person receiving medical care
- Technician — the healthcare professional performing the procedure
- Scan — an imaging examination

5. Communicating with empathy

- Communication is more than giving orders or collecting information.
- Use a calm tone of voice and simple language.
- Eye contact, posture and facial expression also communicate information.
- Visual support, gestures and repetition can help when language is a barrier.
- A calm and empathetic professional helps create a safer environment.

6. Model dialogue

Technician: Good morning, my name is Anna. I am your radiotherapy technician today.

Patient: Good morning.

Technician: Please follow my instructions carefully. Lie still during the session.

Patient: Okay.

Technician: Do you have any allergies or metal implants?

Patient: No.

Technician: Perfect, thank you. Let's begin.

Role-play activity

Student A: You are the radiology/radiotherapy technician.

Student B: You are the patient.

Include an introduction, at least two instructions and two safety questions.

Then swap roles.

Focus on clear pronunciation, simple language and a reassuring tone.

Quick check

How would you introduce yourself to a patient?

How do you ask a patient not to move?

How do you ask about allergies?

What does “consent form” mean?

Name two examples of non-verbal communication.

Key takeaways

Introduce yourself and explain your role.

Use short, clear instructions.

Ask essential safety questions before the procedure.

Speak slowly and calmly.

Remember: good communication improves cooperation, safety and patient experience.